



FREE PROMOTER PLAYBOOK

STOP PAYING ARTISTS YOUR PROFIT.

The Promoter's Booking Playbook.
Know your break-even before you make the offer.

INSIDE: ONE SHOW, RUN THE RIGHT WAY

Break-even

400 tix

Artist fee

\$5,000

You keep at 550

\$4,500

For independent promoters booking club nights, concerts and tours.

PROMOTEROS.COM

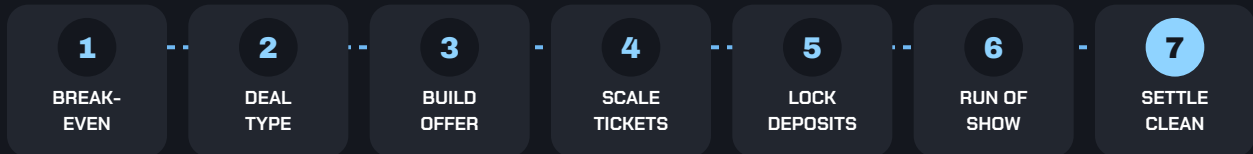
BEFORE YOU START

MOST SHOWS DON'T LOSE MONEY AT THE DOOR. THEY LOSE IT IN THE OFFER.

You can pack a room and still walk out with nothing. It happens when the deal was wrong, the costs were guessed, the ticket prices didn't cover the math, or settlement night turned into an argument with no paperwork.

This playbook is the system: seven steps, in the order you do them, from "should I book this artist?" to "everyone's paid and I made money." Use it on your next show.

THE SYSTEM · 7 STEPS



1 Know your break-even before you make an offer

2 Pick the right deal type

3 Build an offer the agent takes seriously

4 Scale your tickets

5 Lock deposits and the paper trail

6 Run the night with a run of show

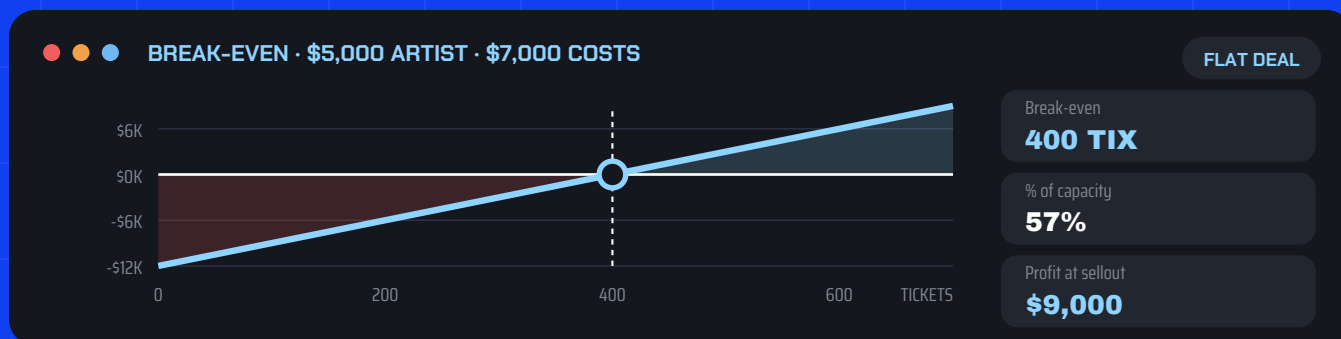
7 Settle clean

+ The 10 mistakes that eat promoter profit

The example we'll use all the way through: a headliner asking \$5,000, a 700-capacity room, \$7,000 in other show costs, and an average ticket that nets you \$30 after fees.

STEP 1

KNOW YOUR BREAK-EVEN BEFORE YOU MAKE AN OFFER



Break-even is the number of tickets you need to sell to cover every dollar you'll spend. If you don't know it, you're not making an offer, you're placing a bet.

The formula

Break-even tickets = (Artist fee + All other costs) ÷ Your net per ticket
 $(\$5,000 + \$7,000) ÷ \$30 = 400 \text{ tickets}$

List every cost. The ones you forget are the ones that hurt.

COST	EXAMPLE	EASY TO FORGET
Venue rent / minimum	\$2,000	Bar minimums, cleaning fee, overtime past curfew
Production (sound, lights, LED)	\$1,500	Load-in labor, backline the rider asks for
Marketing	\$1,500	Flyer design, content, boosted posts in the last week
Staff and security	\$1,000	Extra security for a bigger crowd, door staff, runner
Hospitality and travel	\$1,000	Hotel, ground transport, rider food and drinks
Total other costs	\$7,000	

The rule of thumb

If break-even is more than **60% of capacity**, the deal is tight. Here it's 400 of 700, or 57%. Workable, but there's not much room for a rainy night. Either negotiate the fee, trim costs, or raise prices before you send the offer.

Also check the ticket ceiling: sell out at your planned prices and see what you'd make. If a sellout only earns you a few hundred dollars, the risk isn't worth it.

STEP 2

PICK THE RIGHT DEAL TYPE



The deal decides who carries the risk. Same artist, same night, very different outcomes. Here's our example show under four common deals.

DEAL TYPE	HOW IT WORKS	BEST WHEN
Flat guarantee	Artist gets a fixed fee no matter what. You keep everything above costs.	You're confident the show sells. Highest upside, highest risk.
Guarantee vs. %	Artist gets the guarantee or a % of net after expenses, whichever is bigger.	Standard for touring acts. Shares the upside.
Door deal	No guarantee. Artist gets a split (e.g. 80/20) of net after expenses.	New market, unproven draw. Lowest risk for you.
Guarantee + bonus	Fixed fee plus a bonus when a ticket number is hit (e.g. +\$1,000 at 600 sold).	You want to motivate the artist to promote.

What you keep, by deal and by tickets sold

TICKETS SOLD	FLAT \$5,000	\$5,000 VS 70% OF NET	80/20 DOOR DEAL
400 (break-even)	\$0	\$0	\$1,000
550	\$4,500	\$2,850	\$1,900
700 (sold out)	\$9,000	\$4,200	\$2,800

Net = ticket revenue minus the \$7,000 in other costs. Artist payout is not included in "other costs."

The takeaway: a flat guarantee makes you the most money on a big night and the most pain on a slow one. A door deal protects you but caps your upside. Run all three before you pick. Don't pick from habit.

STEP 3

BUILD AN OFFER THE AGENT TAKES SERIOUSLY

ARTIST OFFER		INTERNAL			
Artist	Headliner	Costs	\$7,000	SEND OFFER PDF ↓ ✓ READY FOR THE AGENT	
Date	Sat · 10 PM	Break-even	400		
Deal	\$5K vs 70%	Profit @550	\$2,850		
Deposit	50%	Sellout	\$4,200		

Agents get a lot of offers. The ones that get answered fast are complete, clear, and show you did the math. A sloppy offer tells them you'll be a sloppy settlement.

Every offer should include

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Artist, date, city, venue name and capacity | ☐ Set time, set length, doors and curfew |
| ☐ Deal type and amounts (guarantee, % split, bonus triggers) | ☐ What you cover: hotel, ground, hospitality, backline |
| ☐ Ticket prices by tier and the gross potential at sellout | ☐ Radius clause (how far and how long they can't play nearby) |
| ☐ Show expenses you'll deduct before any split (with a cap) | ☐ Marketing plan and on-sale date |
| ☐ Deposit amount and due date, and when the balance is paid | ☐ Offer expiration date and your contact info |

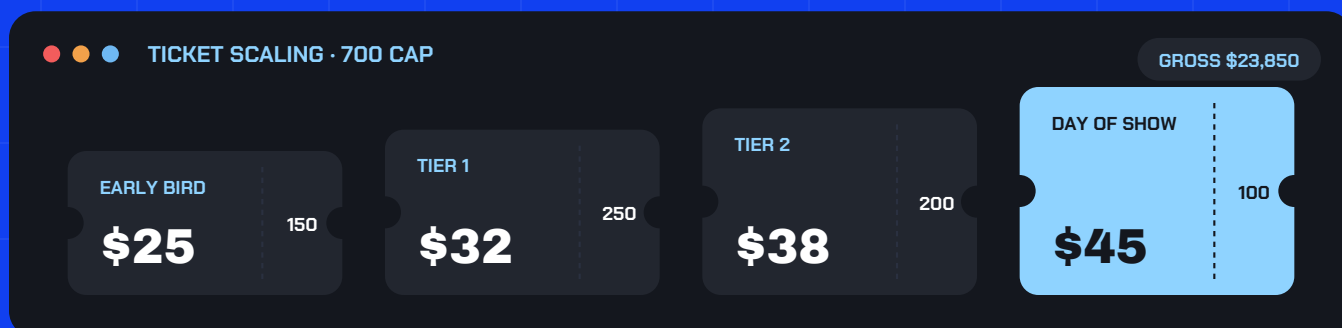
Two versions of the same offer

Keep an **artist version** (what the agent sees: the deal, the terms, the logistics) and an **internal version** (what you see: your costs, your break-even, your profit at every ticket level). Never send the internal one by accident.

Booking a lineup? Write a separate offer sheet for each artist, but keep one budget for the night. Supporting acts' fees go into your costs, and that changes your break-even.

STEP 4

SCALE YOUR TICKETS



Ticket scaling means splitting your capacity into price tiers. It builds urgency early and lets fans who wait pay more.

TIER	QTY	PRICE	GROSS
Early bird	150	\$25	\$3,750
Tier 1	250	\$32	\$8,000
Tier 2	200	\$38	\$7,600
Day of show	100	\$45	\$4,500
Total	700		\$23,850

Average \$34 face value. After ticketing fees, card fees and any taxes, plan for about \$30 net, which is the number your break-even uses.

Scaling rules that work

- **Make early bird small and real.** When it sells out, say so. That's your first urgency post.
- **Never drop prices late.** It teaches your audience to wait. Add value instead: a free drink before 11, a VIP upgrade.
- **Price off your break-even, not the competition.** If the math needs \$30 net, don't sell at \$20 because a club down the street does.
- **Know your gross potential.** Agents ask for it. It's the total if every ticket sells at every tier.

STEP 5

LOCK DEPOSITS AND THE PAPER TRAIL

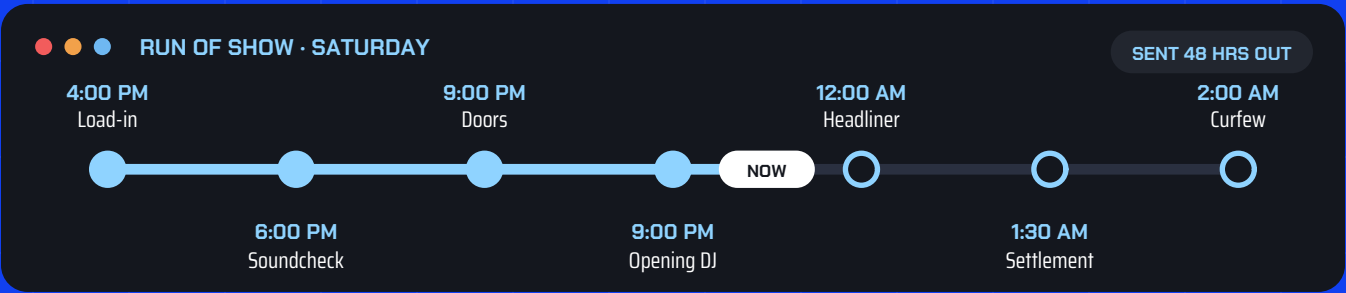
DEPOSITS · SATURDAY LINEUP				CONTRACTS SIGNED
Headliner	\$5,000		50%	50% PAID
Opener	\$800		100%	PAID
Local DJ	\$300		0%	DUE

Deposits are normal and they protect both sides. Common practice is **50% of the guarantee** when the contract is signed, with the balance paid on show night or at settlement. Some agents take a fixed dollar amount instead.

- Get the signed contract before you send any money.
- Pay by a traceable method, and save every receipt with the show.
- Write down the cancellation terms: what happens to the deposit if the artist cancels, or if you do.
- Track what's paid and what's still owed per artist. With three acts on one night, this is where money goes missing.

STEP 6

RUN THE NIGHT WITH A RUN OF SHOW



A run of show is the minute-by-minute plan for the night. Send it to the artist's team, the venue and your staff at least 48 hours out.

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS	OWNER
4:00 PM	Load-in, production setup	Production
6:00 PM	Soundcheck (headliner, then openers)	Tour manager
9:00 PM	Doors	Door manager
9:00 PM	Opening DJ	Stage manager
12:00 AM	Headliner (90 min)	Stage manager
1:30 AM	Settlement meeting	Promoter + TM
2:00 AM	Curfew, lights up	Venue

STEP 7

SETTLE CLEAN

Settlement is where you and the artist's tour manager sit down, go through the numbers, and pay out. A clean settlement gets you rebooked. A messy one gets you a reputation.

Settlement night, step by step

1. Pull final ticket counts from your ticketing platform. Count comps separately.
2. Total the gross, then subtract fees and taxes to get net box office.
3. List every expense you agreed could be deducted, with receipts. Stay under the cap in the contract.
4. Run the deal: guarantee, or % of net, or split, and any bonus that got triggered.
5. Subtract the deposit already paid. That's the balance due tonight.
6. Both sides sign the settlement sheet. Each keeps a copy.
7. Pay the balance and save the proof of payment with the show.

Our example, 550 tickets on a \$5,000 vs 70% deal

SETTLEMENT SHEET · 550 SOLD

Net box office	\$16,500
Less expenses	-\$7,000
Net after expenses	\$9,500
70% vs \$5,000	\$6,650
Less deposit	-\$2,500

PROMOTER

TOUR MANAGER

BALANCE DUE TONIGHT

\$4,150

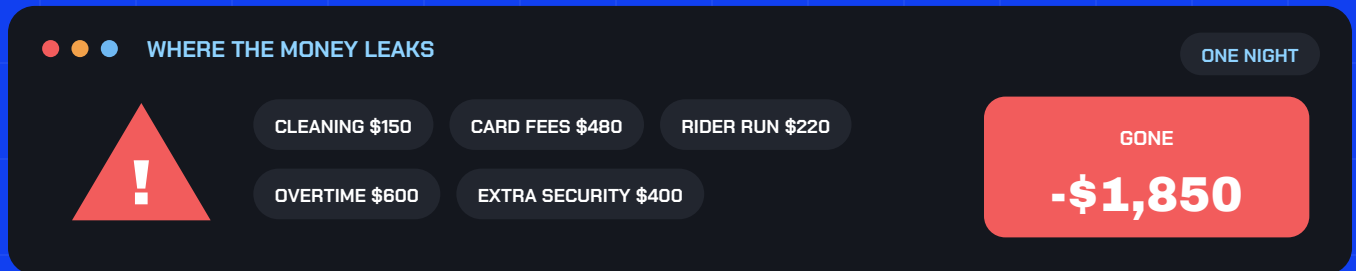
PROMOTER KEEPS

\$2,850

Have the settlement sheet filled in before the TM sits down. Walking in with the numbers already run, and the receipts behind them, ends most arguments before they start.

BONUS

THE 10 MISTAKES THAT EAT PROMOTER PROFIT



01 Making an offer without a break-even.

You're guessing. Run the number first, every time.

02 Forgetting small costs.

Cleaning fees, card fees, rider runs. Twenty small costs add up to one bad night.

03 Taking a flat guarantee in a new market.

No data on the draw? Use a door deal or a vs. deal until you have it.

04 No cap on deductible expenses.

Agents will push back on open-ended expenses. Put a number on it.

05 Discounting tickets in the last week.

It trains fans to wait and cuts your net per ticket.

06 Sending money before a signed contract.

No signature, no deposit.

07 Losing track of deposits across a lineup.

Track paid and owed per artist, not per show.

08 No run of show.

Late sets, missed curfew, overtime fees. All preventable.

09 Settling from memory.

Bring the sheet, the counts, and the receipts. Get signatures.

10 Keeping it all in texts and spreadsheets.

Offers, deposits, settlements and tasks scattered across five apps is how money leaks.

THIS IS WHAT A CLEAN SETTLEMENT LOOKS LIKE.

A real settlement report from a 1,000-capacity show, generated by Promoter OS. Names and contact details are blurred.

PROMOTER OS SETTLEMENT REPORT



Capacity 1000

August 28, 2026
Settled 9/15/2026

[01] FINANCIAL SUMMARY

Metric	Projected	Actual	Variance
Revenue	\$8,501.19	\$8,501.19	\$0.00
Expenses	\$4,684.25	\$4,540.86	-\$143.39
Net Profit	\$3,175.94	\$3,319.33	\$143.39

[02] ATTENDANCE BREAKDOWN

Tier	Price	Projected	Actual	Variance	Revenue
Last Tier \$20	\$20.00	89	89	0	\$1,780.00
Standard \$15	\$15.00	109	109	0	\$1,635.00
Duo Pack (\$16/ticket)	\$16.00	100	100	0	\$1,600.00
Tier \$30	\$30.00	6	6	0	\$180.00
Other online tiers (blended)	\$12.81	32	32	0	\$410.00
Free RSVP	\$0.00	0	30	30	\$0.00
Door cash (lump sum, U21 removed)	\$1,020.00	1	1	0	\$1,020.00
Own Stripe checkout (lump sum)	\$1,876.19	1	1	0	\$1,876.19

[03] EXPENSE BREAKDOWN

Expense Item	Projected	Actual	Variance
Talent			
	\$300.00	\$300.00	\$0.00
	\$200.00	\$200.00	\$0.00
rider_hospitality	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
General			
ent	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
venue	\$3,200.00	\$3,056.61	-\$143.39
security	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
gate_staff	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
Marketing			
radio	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
marketing	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
paid_social	\$412.60	\$412.60	\$0.00
Production			
camera	\$400.00	\$400.00	\$0.00
production	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00

PROJECTED VS. ACTUAL

Every line shows what you planned, what happened, and the difference.

EVERY TICKET TIER

Online tiers, door cash, comps and RSVPs, counted to the dollar.

EVERY EXPENSE

Talent, venue, marketing and production, grouped and totaled.

NET PROFIT

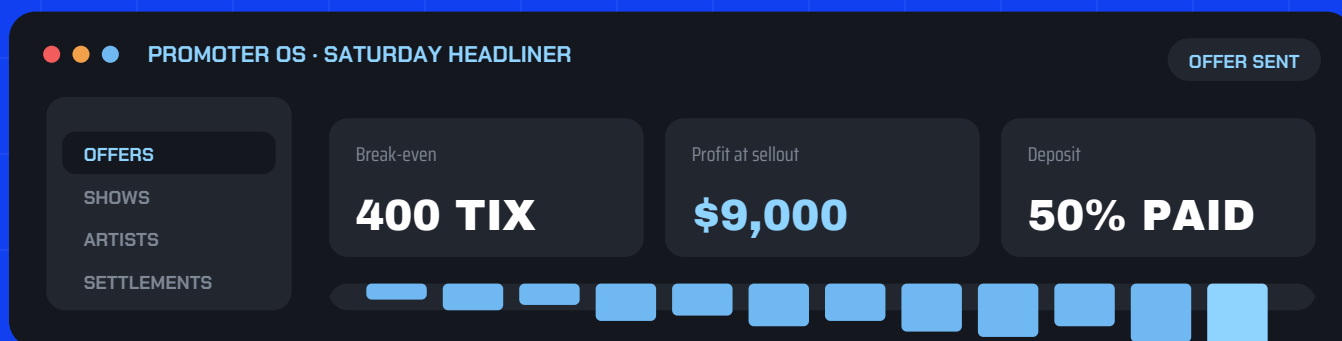
\$3,319

\$143 better than projected on this show.

NOW DO IT IN MINUTES

EVERYTHING IN THIS PLAYBOOK IS BUILT INTO PROMOTER OS.

You just read seven steps. Promoter OS runs them for you in one place, so the math is done before you hit send and the paperwork is ready before the TM sits down.



BREAK-EVEN AND PROFIT	See your break-even and profit at every ticket level before you make the offer.
OFFER PDFS	Artist version and internal version from the same deal, one click each. Email them from the app.
EVERY DEAL TYPE	Flat, vs. deals, door splits and bonuses, with percentage or fixed-dollar deposits.
MULTI-ARTIST LINEUPS	An offer sheet per artist, one budget for the night.
TICKET SCALING	Build your tiers and see gross potential instantly.
DEPOSITS, TASKS AND RUN OF SHOW	Know what's paid, what's owed and who's doing what.
SETTLEMENT SHEETS	Run the numbers, print the sheet, get it signed.

START YOUR 14-DAY FREE TRIAL →

promoteros.com - Plug in your next show and see the numbers today.